

The Wounded Image: Reclaiming "Abba" as the True Face of God's Fatherhood

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Abstract

Many people who believe in God still find it hard to trust Him as a Father. This report addresses that difficulty using both theology and honest reflection on how the human heart actually works. Its center of gravity is one small Aramaic word: Abba, the intimate, unguarded way Jesus spoke to God, and the same word Paul says every believer is given the right to use (Romans 8:15). Our first experience of a father teaches us, long before we can put it into words, what kind of thing a father is: safe or unsafe, near or far, warm or cold. When that first experience is wounded, we tend to hand God the bill. This paper argues that the Trinity, the Incarnation, and the cross—rather than our own history—should have the last word on who God the Father actually is. It then turns to the marriage-and-family question at the heart of this course: because human fatherhood was designed to image divine fatherhood (Ephesians 3:14–15), a husband and father can consciously reflect the way God expresses His fatherhood, and in doing so he shapes both the faith of his family and the kind of man he himself becomes.

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Introduction

Most of us know a father before we know anything about God. Maybe he was there, maybe he wasn’t, and either way we learned something from it. We learned it in small ways: whether the sound of his footsteps coming near meant safety or fear, and whether love was something we had to earn. So by the time anyone tells us God is our Father, that word is already loaded and sometimes carries its own weight. It comes with a face attached (Rizzuto, 1979), and for a lot of people it is not a kind face.

This report addresses that problem. Everything here hangs on one word Jesus used: Abba. It is how he talked to God (Mark 14:36), and Paul says the Spirit gives the same word to everyone God adopts (Romans 8:15; Galatians 4:6). The argument is easy to say but hard to actually live: healing a wounded picture of God the Father means learning to believe Abba even when your history says otherwise. Let us also be clear about blame. Scripture puts responsibility on the person who made the choice (James 1:13–14). A father who was absent or cruel is that way as a result of his own choosing.

The Biblical Standard: What God’s Fatherhood Actually Is

Before we can say a father wounds the image of God, we have to know what that image is. God feels for us the way a good father feels for his children, and the comparison starts with God, not with us (Psalm 103:13, English Standard Version, 2001/2016). In fact the direction only runs one way: no one is a father the way God is a Father, because His fatherhood is the origin and the measure of every other kind (Catholic Church, 1997, no. 239). So when Scripture shows God fathering His people, it is not borrowing a nice human picture; it is showing us the original that every human father is a copy of.

Read across the whole story, God expresses His fatherhood in a handful of recognizable ways, and it is worth naming them plainly because these are the exact things a wounded person doubts. First, He initiates. God moves before we do: the father in the parable

spots his son far off and runs (Luke 15:20), and “we love because he first loved us” (1 John 4:19). Second, He delights. God says He is pleased with His Son before that Son has done anything public (Matthew 3:17); the approval comes first, not as a reward for a finished performance. Third, He is present. He is not a distant administrator but the one who promises, “I will never leave you nor forsake you” (Hebrews 13:5). Fourth, He provides and protects, giving good gifts to His children the way a decent father would, only more so (Matthew 7:9–11). Fifth, He disciplines—but the point of it is to form a child, not to crush one, and Scripture ties it directly to love: “the Lord disciplines the one he loves” (Hebrews 12:6). Sixth, He restores; He puts the robe and the ring on a boy who had not even finished his apology (Luke 15:22). And underneath all of it, He gives Himself, spending His own Son rather than protecting Himself at our expense (Romans 8:32). Taken together, that is the standard: initiating, delighting, present, providing, forming, forgiving, self-giving love.

Paul uses ‘Abba’ in the exact place where believers start feeling like hired help: “you did not receive the spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, ‘Abba! Father!’” (Romans 8:15). It is not a nice detail on the side; it is the entire point.

Three Anchors Beneath the Word Abba

The Trinity: Fatherhood Older Than the World

There were no human fathers yet when the Father was already loving the Son. Jesus says it plainly: “you loved me before the foundation of the world” (John 17:24). That makes human fatherhood the copy, not the original. Our own fathers were working from an echo of something whole, and sometimes the echo reached them badly distorted. That says something about them. It says nothing about the sound they were copying.

The Incarnation: A Face We Were Not Left to Imagine

If all we had were arguments about God’s character, a hurt person would fill in the blanks with the worst father he knows. That is what people who are hurting do. But Jesus told

Philip, “Whoever has seen me has seen the Father” (John 14:9). So we can look at who he ate with, who he forgave, and what actually made him angry. We do not have to guess what God is like. We were shown.

The Atonement and Adoption: Abba as a Legal Fact

Calling God Abba is not just permitted; something had to happen first. God sent his Son “to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons,” and only after that does Paul say God sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, “Abba! Father!” (Galatians 4:4–6). The adoption is already done. It does not wait for us to feel adopted, which means most of the healing is catching up emotionally to something that is already true on paper.

The Distortion: How Earthly Fathers Wound the Image of Abba

There is usually a gap between that picture and the one we grew up with. The prophets knew it, which is why they keep insisting that God is not like the fathers Israel actually had (Hosea 11:1–4).

The Absent Father

A father who is gone, or who is home but not really there, teaches a child that people cannot be counted on. Years later that turns into a God who exists but never shows up (Sowers, 2010). Scripture answers that with a promise: “My father and my mother have forsaken me, but the Lord will take me in” (Psalm 27:10).

The Authoritarian or Harsh Father

A father who rules by control and hands out approval only when it is earned teaches another lesson: love is a wage, a payment for good behavior. Grow up with that and God becomes a scorekeeper—which is strange, because the father in Luke 15 is running down a road.

The Abusive Father

When the father was the danger, closeness itself stops feeling safe. The very words Scripture uses to pull us toward God—nearness, touch, submission, a father’s authority—are the same words that abuse has already ruined. It usually takes safe people, over years, to show that those words can mean something else, but most of all it takes seeing what the true fatherhood of God is actually like.

Where the Cosmic Conflict Fits—and Where It Does Not

Scripture knew that our earliest relationships shape what we expect from love (Matthew 7:9–11). The wound belongs to the father who caused it (James 1:13–14). What the cosmic conflict explains is the next part: there is an enemy whose whole strategy is lying about God’s character (2 Corinthians 4:4), and he has every reason to keep a hurt person from ever checking that lie against the real thing.

The Healing Pathway: Reclaiming God as Abba

Theological Re-Parenting

Healing starts by meeting the God the Bible actually describes instead of the narrow version our personal history handed us. If God feels indifferent, there is the Shepherd who goes after one sheep (John 10:14). If God feels like a scorekeeper, there is the Warrior who “fights for you” (Deuteronomy 1:30). If God feels unfair, there is the Judge who gets it right (Isaiah 30:18).

Church as Surrogate Family

Jesus said family is not only about blood: “Whoever does the will of God, he is my brother and sister and mother” (Mark 3:35). People who show up for each other, keep showing up, and do not disappear will slowly teach someone what safety feels like, and Paul’s picture of older believers walking with younger ones shows the shape of it (Titus 2:1–8).

Case Illustration

Theology sometimes does not reach the deepest part of a person. Brennan Manning (2015), a Catholic priest, grew up with an alcoholic father whose moods decided everything,

and he says learning to call God Abba took most of his life. The distortion his own father had stamped onto the word “God” took that long to undo. His story is a warning and a hope at once: a father can bend the image badly, and the image can still be straightened.

Reflecting Abba: The Husband and Father as a Living Image of God’s Fatherhood

Everything above has one more thing to say, and it is the reason this belongs in a course on marriage and the family. If a wounded father can distort the word “Father,” then a healthy one can help repair it. Scripture says “every family in heaven and on earth” is named after the Father (Ephesians 3:14–15), which means fatherhood on earth is not a human invention that we then project upward onto God; it is the other way around. The Church puts it as strongly as possible: in “revealing and reliving on earth the very fatherhood of God,” a man is called to secure the united growth of everyone in his family (John Paul II, 1981, no. 25). That is a staggering job description. The earthly father is not the source of that love; he is a mirror of it, and his whole task is to keep the mirror clean and pointed in the right direction.

This also names something our own culture keeps missing. We are often told that ours is a society “without fathers,” and the absence is felt not as freedom but as a lack (Francis, 2016, no. 176). The answer is not fathers who dominate, and not fathers who vanish, but fathers who image Abba on purpose.

How a Father Reflects the Way God Loves

The reflection becomes concrete when we lay it beside the marks of God’s fatherhood named earlier. God initiates; so a father pursues his children first, offering closeness before they have done anything to earn it, instead of waiting to be impressed. God delights; so a father blesses and affirms his child before the report card, the way “this is my beloved Son” came before any public success (Matthew 3:17). God is present; so a father simply shows up, over and over, which is the direct answer to the wound the absent father leaves. God provides and protects, and a father does the ordinary, unglamorous work of shelter, food, and safety. God disciplines to form and not to crush, so Scripture warns fathers twice: “do not provoke your

children to anger, but bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord” (Ephesians 6:4), and “do not provoke your children, lest they become discouraged” (Colossians 3:21). God restores, so a father forgives and keeps the door open the way the father in Luke 15 did. And beneath all of it, God gives Himself—which is why a husband is told to “love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her” (Ephesians 5:25). A father also passes on the faith itself, teaching his children the way of the Lord as part of daily life (Deuteronomy 6:6–7). Put together, a father reflects Abba not by being perfect but by loving in the same shape God does: first, freely, faithfully, and at cost to himself.

What It Does to His Family

A father who loves this way is, whether he intends it or not, the first theology his children ever learn. Long before they can read a catechism, they are drawing conclusions about whether “Father” is a safe word, and their father is the main evidence. When his love initiates and does not have to be earned, the child grows up expecting God to be approachable rather than suspicious. When he is present, the child is far less likely to meet the “God who exists but never shows up.” When he disciplines without cruelty, the child does not confuse authority with danger. In this way a home becomes a place where Abba is believable, and the wife is honored in the process, since a husband who images the self-giving of Christ toward her sets the emotional temperature of the whole house. The Church sees ordinary family life as exactly where this healing gets handed on from one generation to the next (Catholic Church, 1997, no. 2214). Most powerfully, a father who does this breaks a cycle. The distortion that gets passed down a family line (Malachi 4:6) can stop with one man who decides to reflect the original instead of repeating the damage he received.

What It Does to the Man Himself

None of this works if a father tries to be Abba on his own strength, because a mirror cannot generate light. He can only reflect what he has received, which means the first thing fatherhood asks of a man is that he learn to be a son—that he let himself be loved by God

before he is asked to love like God. This is quietly good news for the man himself. Fathering this way keeps confronting him with his own limits and his own wounds, and it becomes one of the main places he is sanctified: he has to forgive the way he wants to be forgiven, be patient past the end of his patience, and stay when leaving would be easier. It frees him, too. A man who knows he is already a beloved son does not need to run his home like a scorekeeper or prove his worth through his children's achievements. And there is a repair that runs backward: as he practices being the kind of father Abba is, his own distorted picture of God often starts to straighten, because he finally has a true experience of the thing the word was supposed to mean. In loving his family the way he was first loved, he becomes more himself, and more like Christ.

Conclusion

Fathers were supposed to be a small copy of something that starts in God, not the other way around (Ephesians 3:14–15). Sin cracked the copy. That is why the word “Father” leaves so many people uneasy instead of at peace. The question is which one we read through: the cracked copy, or the God who has already shown us what he is like.

None of this undoes what happened. That was never the offer. The offer is that it does not get the final say, because the adoption was settled by someone else (Romans 8:15–17; Galatians 4:4–7). We get to say Abba anyway—and the father who reflects Him gets to make that word believable for the people who live in his house.

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